

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Friend Test

Marcus, on a Wednesday in early December, sat at his desk in Room 36 with a worksheet in front of him.

The worksheet had two columns.

The left column was titled *What I said to myself*. The right column was titled *What I would have said to my best friend*.

Mr. Patel had handed the worksheet out at the start of class. He had said, *friends. We are doing one exercise today. We have been talking about the Compassionate Witness for three weeks. Today we are going to test her. The test is simple. I want you to write, in the left column, the actual sentences you said to yourself this week when something went wrong. Then I want you to imagine – and this is where most of you are going to do real work – I want you to imagine that your best friend came to you with the same situation, and I want you to write, in the right column, what you would have said to them.*

He paused.

That is the exercise. The exercise is private. I am not going to read it. You are going to keep it in your notebook.

He paused again.

One last thing. If, when you compare the two columns, the right column is much kinder than the left – that is the Friend Test. That is the gap we have been talking about. The Friend Test tells you, in the most direct possible way, that you are talking to

yourself in a voice you would not let anybody else use on your friend.

He sat down at his desk.

The cohort wrote.

Marcus wrote the left column quickly.

The thing that went wrong this week was that I lost my temper at Aaliyah on Sunday. I did not call her names — I have not done that since fourth grade. But I said something sharp to her about a thing she had borrowed from my room and broken. The thing was small. It was a pen. I do not actually care about the pen. I was, in the moment, just frustrated about something else, and I took it out on her. She said I am sorry and walked away looking small. I have been carrying it since Sunday.

What I said to myself: you are a bad brother. You promised yourself when you were six, after the bike thing, that you would not do this kind of thing to Aaliyah. You have been doing it anyway. You are the thing you said you would not be. You are going to keep being it. The August 14 ice cream thing is a joke if you are going to act like this on a random Sunday in December.

He read it.

His chest did the thing it does when the Critic is loud.

He sat with it for a minute.

Then he read the right-column prompt.

What would you say to your best friend if they came to you with the same situation?

He sat there for two minutes. He looked at the prompt. He looked at his left column. He picked up the pen. He wrote a sentence. He scratched it out. He wrote another sentence. He scratched that one out too. He was having, for the first time in his life, a very specific cognitive experience, and the experience was: I genuinely do not know how to be kind to myself.

He knew how to be kind to other people. If Theo, his best cohort friend, came to him tomorrow and said *I lost it on my sister last week, I said something sharp, I cannot shake it — Marcus would have a response ready. Marcus's response would be something like Theo. You were stressed. It was one moment. You did not call her names. You apologized — and you can apologize again if you want to. She is going to be fine. You are going to be fine. The carrying is not helping her. The carrying is just punishing you. Put it down.*

Marcus knew how to write that paragraph for Theo.

Marcus could not write that paragraph for himself.

When he tried, the words came out wrong. The words came out with a *but* attached. *You apologized — but you still meant it when you said it. You are a good brother — but a good brother would not have said that. It was one moment — but it was a moment that revealed who you really are.*

The *but* is the Critic.

The Critic has spent twelve years getting good at sneaking *buts* into the sentence. The Critic knows that an outright attack will trigger Marcus's defenses. The Critic knows that a sneaky *but* will slide past the defenses and land in the soft part underneath. So the Critic delivers the Compassionate Witness's opening line, and then adds a *but*, and the whole sentence collapses back into self-punishment.

This is how good the Critic is. It is impressive, in a way. The Critic is not stupid. The Critic has been training on Marcus for his entire conscious life and it knows where every soft spot is. The Critic can mimic the Compassionate Witness, almost flawlessly, for the first six words, and then it does the thing.



The work of the next two years — and we are being honest about the timeline here, this is not a one-lesson fix — is to start catching the *but*. To notice, when the sentence starts to turn, that the turn is happening.

To stop the sentence at the *but*.

To say to yourself: *no, finish the actual sentence. The Compassionate Witness sentence. Without the but.*

You apologized, and that is what accountability looks like. You meant it when you said the sharp thing because you were twelve and frustrated, and that is what twelve-year-olds do when they are frustrated. You are allowed to make a mistake of that size and still be a person worth loving. You are not the worst thing you have ever said. You are the whole person, across years, who said one sharp thing on a Sunday in December and one kind thing on a Monday, and over time the average is going to be okay.

That is a sentence with no *but* in it.

It does not feel quite true to Marcus yet. That is okay. He did not write it because it felt true. He wrote it because Mr. Patel asked him to write it, and because the writing is the practice, and because — and this is the part the curriculum does not tell you out loud, but is absolutely true — *you have to write a sentence many times before you get to believe it*. The believing is not the prerequisite to the writing.

The writing is the prerequisite to the believing.

You write the new sentence. You write it badly. You write it again. You write it a hundred times, in journal after journal, in moment after moment, until one day — and it will not feel like a single day, it will feel like a slow leak — the new sentence has become the more natural one, and the *but* has lost a little of its grip, and the Compassionate Witness is, for thirty seconds at a stretch, the louder voice.

That is how this works. It is slow. It is not glamorous. It is not a single epiphany. It is just the daily practice of writing the sentence without the *but*, over and over, until the *but* gets tired and gives up some ground.

It works. It really, actually works. Adults who do this in their thirties and forties — people who finally figure out that they can talk to themselves the way they have, all their lives, talked to their friends — describe the change as one of the most consequential of their adult lives. *Why did no one tell me this when I was younger*, they say. *Why did no one tell me when I was twelve*.

Somebody is telling you. We are telling you. The book is the somebody.

Catch the *but*. Finish the sentence without it. Do it again tomorrow.

That is the practice.



Marcus, after class, walked to Aaliyah's bedroom that afternoon. Aaliyah was on her bed, doing homework.

Marcus said, *Aal. Sunday. The pen.*

Aaliyah said, *Marcus. I have already forgotten about it. You are doing the thing.*

Marcus said, *what thing.*

Aaliyah said, *the thing where you carry something for four days and then come find me. I have seen you do this since I was six. I have, in fact, been counting on you doing it. You always come find me.*

Marcus laughed.

He said, *Aal. The pen.*

Aaliyah said, *Marcus. The pen was a pen. You snapped at me. You snap at me sometimes. I snap at you sometimes. We are*

siblings. *The snapping is – it is the lowest level of cohabitation problem in the history of cohabitation. I am eight. I am the most resilient unit in this house. I have already moved on.*

Marcus said, *I am sorry I snapped.*

Aaliyah said, *I forgive you. Can you leave my room now.*

Marcus said, *okay.*

He left her room. He walked back to his own room.

He wrote, in his notebook:

Aaliyah is the most resilient unit in this house. I am writing this down because the Critic, in four days, when she tries to pull this back out, is going to need to be reminded.

He closed the notebook. He went to dinner.

The Critic, that night at eleven-twenty, did try to pull the Sunday thing back out.

Marcus, in bed, said in his head: *Aaliyah forgave me. She told me she had already moved on. The Critic is recycling old material. The pen is done.*

The Critic was, for that night, quieter than usual.

This is what the Friend Test does, when you actually use it. It does not silence the Critic forever. The Critic is the Critic. The Critic is going to be there in adulthood and middle age and old age. But the Friend Test gives you a check. The Friend Test gives you a way of asking, in the middle of self-flagellation, *would I let anybody use these exact words on Aaliyah?*

The answer is always no.

The answer being no is the wedge.

The wedge is what lets the Compassionate Witness get a word in. That is how this works.

Use the test.

You will get better at it.

– J.A.R.